

Weapon of **LAST RESORT**

The Indian Army earmarks a division of the Rashtriya Rifles for deployment against the Maoists. Should the men in olive green be asked to counter another insurgency?

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with Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Last month, the Indian Army headquarters in Delhi's South Block sent a terse directive to its Northern Army Command. The army's largest operational command with over 3,00,000 soldiers was asked to immediately identify eight Rashtriya Rifles (RR) battalions and two sector headquarters (each manages four battalions) which could be earmarked for anti-Naxal operations. This dramatic and highly controversial move comes on the heels of the latest deadly Maoist attack on a passenger train. Eight battalions of the RR means 8,000 soldiers the Indian Army will commit to the battle against the Maoists in central India if the Government decides on its revised strategy to tackle its biggest internal security challenge.

Earmarking these troops, which nearly make a division, says senior army officials, is just one step short of a full deployment. The Government has already begun reaching for its weapon of



"Policing a country in a troubled neighbourhood makes the task more difficult. And that with insufficient police stations and inadequate and ill-equipped police makes it formidable."

P. CHIDAMBARAM
Home Minister

